A later European writer wrote not much more glowingly about Mildenhall:

> John Mildenhall was not an estimable character. In plain words, he was a dishonest scoundrel. He cheated, or tried to cheat, Akbar with an assumption of ambassadorial dignity; he tried to cheat the Company with concessions that, in all probability, he had never received; he ended up by cheating his own employers, the merchants in London.

Nonetheless, admitted the writer, ‘he was a pioneer of Anglo-Indian enterprise, no less enterprising than his many enterprising successors’. So insignificant was Mildenhall’s passage at the Mughal court that there is no record of it in the Persian chronicles. Of his ‘enterprising successors’, however, the impact was all too evident. Ever since King Philip II’s Spanish Armada had been defeated in 1588, the domination of the Iberian powers was doomed. Now, the English and the Dutch, with their vastly superior navies, and an increasing demand from the English middle classes for luxury goods, looked determined to step into the breach. The English were especially buoyed since the return in 1580 of Francis Drake, after having successfully circumnavigated the globe. Depending on whose account you listened to, Drake was a privateer, pioneer, slaver, or pirate. King Phillip II was especially furious at his plundering of Spanish ports in the Caribbean, but Elizabeth I knighted Drake, and England was ready to inhabit her role as the next big European colonizing power.

The road that brought these English traders and adventurers to Indian shores was a decidedly bloody one. The sixteenth century had seen England convulsed by religious wars, resulting in her being considered something of a rogue and a pariah by Catholic Europe. As a result, the excommunicated* Elizabeth I found herself looking to more exotic shores for trade and commerce. She had sent one Jenkinson, a mercer by profession, to quite a list of dignitaries with grand titles including Shah Tahmasp of Persia, Suleiman the Magnificent of the Ottoman Empire, and Ivan the Terrible of Russia, seeking trade concessions. The particular goods that England was looking for at the close of the sixteenth century were sugar, spices, silk, cotton, and potassium nitrate, for gunpowder. These were the goods, and this was the climate, then, that brought a group of merchants to the court of the ‘Great Mogor’.